
Two Arsenal players lose their place in Premier League XI

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We're basing this Premier League XI on WhoScored ratings, which essentially means Opta statistics and algorithms that generally reward 'doing stuff', so aerially dominant centre-halves are far more likely to be included than calm passers.

Anyway, here we go. At this stage, all candidates must have started 11 of 16 Premier League games.

Goalkeeper: Nick Pope (Newcastle United)

David Raya is sitting on his hands as he earns the Golden Glove and [Dean Henderson has prevented the most goals](#), but the algorithms make Pope the leading goalkeeper in the Premier League this season, taking over from Robin Roefs after his Sunderland side got a mini-paddling from Manchester City. Retains his place in absentia.

Right-back: Daniel Munoz (Crystal Palace)

[There was no right-back in the PFA Team of the Year](#) for 2024/25 season but Arsenal's Jurrien Timber might be impossible to ignore this season. But the numbers put Munoz ahead so far...he claimed his third goal of the season in the 1-0 win at Burnley. He is quietly (well, not so quietly) showing Manchester United's wing-backs how to do the job.

Centre-back: Gabriel (Arsenal)

At this stage of the season, there is a bias in favour of defenders with goal contributions, and Gabriel has one goal and two assists. But he is also the best centre-half in the Premier League bar none. Though Arsenal are having to learn to cope without him right now.

Centre-back: Trevoh Chalobah (Chelsea)

Had we said in August that Chelsea would have one man in this team by mid-December, you might have had a punt at Cole Palmer or perhaps Moises Caicedo. But only Arsenal have conceded fewer goals than Chelsea this season and Chalobah has been central to that record, with three Premier League goals a bonus.

Left-back: Nico O'Reilly (Manchester City)

Slim pickings at left-back – unlike at right-back – with O'Reilly emerging from the pack with a goal and three assists from left-back. It's also booked him a place to the World Cup with England.

Central midfield: Declan Rice (Arsenal)

We had been waiting for the algorithm to align with our eyes on Rice, who has been freed as a creative influence by the signing of Martin Zubimendi. He added his second goal of the Premier League season v Burnley and then his third assist against Tottenham. Probably the best midfielder in Europe bar none.

Central midfield: Bruno Fernandes (Manchester United)

Much maligned but once again, the numbers are on his side. We keep being told that the United formation is curtailing his attacking output, and yet nobody in the Premier League has more assists (six) than Bruno, who has now scored four Premier League goals this season.

Right wing: Bukayo Saka (Arsenal)

Another excellent game for Saka v Tottenham in which he really showed Mohammed Kudus how to be a Premier League right winger. He is defensively diligent as well as insanely productive. After a slow start to the season, Saka is flying once again and now has four Premier League goals. He was the pick of a poor bunch v Wolves.

Attacking midfield: Phil Foden (Manchester City)

Move over Eberechi Eze. Foden now has seven Premier League goals this season after a double in that mental game v Fulham, another v Sunderland and another brace at Crystal Palace. It's interesting that three City players emerge at the top of WhoScored's players of the season. But then they have scored the most goals this season...

Left wing: Jeremy Doku (Manchester City)

[Absolutely phenomenal against Liverpool](#), he scored a goal, won a penalty, dribbled past seven players and created three chances. He then created four chances against Newcastle United but was overshadowed by Harvey Barnes. Only Kudus dribbles past more players but Doku has more end product this season and loses the ball a whole lot less.

Striker: Erling Haaland (Manchester City)

Just casually strolling towards the Golden Boot with 17 Premier League goals in his first 16 games. He looks sharp and he looks absolutely brilliant, clearly taking the summer spend on outrageously expensive strikers as a personal affront. Still the best? Absolutely.

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